UNIT I - WORKING WITH GRAMMAR

Grammar is the system of rules that tells us how words are formed and how they are arranged to make meaningful sentences. Without grammar, words are only a heap of sounds; with grammar, they carry clear meaning. In spoken English, correct grammar makes you easy to understand and creates a good impression. This unit explains the building blocks of English one by one.

1. Sentence Construction

A **sentence** is a group of words arranged in a proper order that expresses a complete thought. It begins with a capital letter in writing and ends with a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark. Every sentence has two essential parts:

- **Subject:** the person, place or thing the sentence is about (who or what does the action).
- **Predicate:** everything that says something about the subject; it always contains a **verb**.

In the sentence *The tall boy kicked the ball*, 'The tall boy' is the subject and 'kicked the ball' is the predicate.

Basic sentence patterns

Pattern	Example	Explanation
Subject + Verb (S+V)	Birds fly.	The verb needs nothing more (intransitive verb).
Subject + Verb + Object (S+V+O)	She reads novels.	The object receives the action (transitive verb).
Subject + Verb + Complement (S+V+C)	He became a doctor.	The complement describes or renames the subject (linking verb).
Subject + Verb + Indirect Object + Direct Object	The teacher gave us homework.	'us' receives the thing; 'homework' is what is given.
Subject + Verb + Object + Complement	They elected him leader.	The complement describes the object.
Subject + Verb + Adverbial	The meeting ends at five.	Adds time, place or manner.

Phrases and clauses

- A **phrase** is a group of words without a subject-verb pair: *in the garden, very fast, to win the race*.
- A **clause** has a subject and a verb. An **independent (main) clause** can stand alone: *I went home*. A **dependent (subordinate) clause** cannot: *because I was tired*.

Rules for building correct sentences

- Keep the usual word order: Subject - Verb - Object. Adjectives come before nouns; adverbs of frequency come before the main verb (*She always smiles*).
- Make the subject and verb agree in number and person.
- Use one tense consistently within a sentence unless the meaning changes.
- Avoid sentence fragments ('Because it rained.') and run-on sentences (two sentences joined without a conjunction or full stop).
- Place modifiers next to the word they describe: *She nearly drove 100 km* and *She drove nearly 100 km* mean different things.

2. Types of Sentences

A. Based on function (purpose)

Type	Purpose	Example	Ends with
Declarative (assertive)	States a fact, opinion or information. Can be affirmative or negative.	India is a large country. / I do not like coffee.	Full stop
Interrogative	Asks a question. Starts with a wh-word or an auxiliary verb.	Where do you live? / Is she at home?	Question mark
Imperative	Gives a command, request, advice or instruction. The subject 'you' is understood.	Open the window. / Please sit down.	Full stop or exclamation mark
Exclamatory	Expresses sudden or strong feeling. Often begins with What or How.	What a lovely view! / How brave he is!	Exclamation mark
Optative	Expresses a wish, prayer or blessing.	May you live long!	Exclamation mark

B. Based on structure

Type	Structure	Example
Simple	One independent clause (one subject-verb unit).	The sun rises in the east.
Compound	Two or more independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (and, but, or, so, yet, for, nor).	She sang, and he played the guitar.
Complex	One independent clause + one or more dependent clauses joined by a subordinating word (because, if, when, although, who, which).	I will call you when I reach home.
Compound-complex	Two or more independent clauses + at least one dependent clause.	Although it was late, she finished her work, and he went home.

Tip for speaking: Use short simple sentences for clarity, and add compound and complex sentences to show detail and connect ideas. A good speaker mixes all four structures.

3. Parts of Speech

Every word in a sentence does a job. Based on the job, words are grouped into **eight parts of speech**: noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction and interjection. Note that the same word can be a different part of speech in different sentences: *Light* (noun) *a light* (adjective) *to light* (verb).

(a) Noun

A noun names a person, place, animal, thing, quality or idea.

Kind	Meaning	Examples
Proper noun	Particular name of a person, place or thing; begins with a capital letter	Kalam, Puducherry, Ganga, Monday
Common noun	General name of a class	boy, city, river, book
Collective noun	Name of a group taken as one	team, class, flock, committee

Kind	Meaning	Examples
Material noun	Name of a substance from which things are made	gold, wood, water, cotton
Abstract noun	Name of a quality, feeling, state or action; cannot be touched	honesty, beauty, childhood, laughter

Nouns may also be **countable** (book, books) or **uncountable** (water, advice, information).

(b) Pronoun

A pronoun is used in place of a noun to avoid repeating it: *Ravi said that **he** was tired.*

Kind	Examples	Sentence
Personal	I, you, he, she, it, we, they; me, him, her, us, them	She helped me.
Possessive	mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs	This pen is mine.
Reflexive / emphatic	myself, yourself, himself, themselves	He hurt himself.
Demonstrative	this, that, these, those	Those are my books.
Interrogative	who, whom, whose, which, what	Whose bag is this?
Relative	who, whom, whose, which, that	The girl who sang is my sister.
Indefinite	someone, anybody, nobody, all, few, each	Everyone was present.

(c) Verb

A verb expresses an action (run, write), a state (be, seem) or an occurrence (become). It is the heart of the sentence.

- **Transitive verbs** need an object (She *wrote* a letter); **intransitive verbs** do not (She *smiled*).
- **Linking verbs** connect the subject to a complement: be, become, seem, look, feel, appear.
- **Regular verbs** form the past with -ed (walk, walked); **irregular verbs** change form (go, went, gone; write, wrote, written).
- **Finite verbs** change with tense and subject; **non-finite** forms are the infinitive (to go), gerund (going) and participles (going, gone).
- **Stative verbs** (know, love, want, own, belong) are not normally used in continuous tenses.

The twelve tenses

Tense shows the time of an action. English has three times (present, past, future), each with four aspects.

Tense	Use	Example (verb: write)
Simple present	Habits, general truths	She writes every day.
Present continuous	Action happening now	She is writing now.
Present perfect	Past action with present result	She has written a letter.
Present perfect continuous	Action started in the past and still going on	She has been writing for an hour.
Simple past	Finished action in the past	She wrote a letter yesterday.
Past continuous	Action in progress at a past time	She was writing when I came.
Past perfect	Action completed before another past action	She had written before I came.

Tense	Use	Example (verb: write)
Past perfect continuous	Longer action up to a past moment	She had been writing for an hour.
Simple future	Decisions, predictions	She will write tomorrow.
Future continuous	Action in progress at a future time	She will be writing at 5 p.m.
Future perfect	Action completed by a future time	She will have written by Monday.
Future perfect continuous	Duration up to a future time	She will have been writing for an hour.

(d) Adjective

An adjective describes or limits a noun or pronoun. It answers: what kind? how many? which? whose?

Kind	Examples
Quality	a *brave* soldier, *cold* water
Quantity	*some* milk, *enough* food, *little* time
Number	*three* pens, *many* students, the *first* row
Demonstrative	*this* house, *those* boys
Possessive	*my* book, *their* car
Interrogative	*Which* road? *What* time?

Order of adjectives (when more than one): opinion, size, age, shape, colour, origin, material - *a lovely small old round red Indian wooden box.*

(e) Adverb

An adverb describes a verb, an adjective or another adverb. It answers: how? when? where? how often? how much?

Kind	Examples
Manner	She speaks *clearly*. He walked *slowly*.
Time	I will come *tomorrow*. They left *early*.
Place	Come *here*. He looked *around*.
Frequency	He *always* smiles. She *rarely* complains.
Degree	It is *very* cold. She is *quite* clever.

Many adverbs are formed by adding **-ly** to an adjective (quick - quickly), but some do not end in -ly (fast, well, hard, late).

(f) Preposition

A preposition shows the relation of a noun or pronoun to another word in the sentence.

- **Time:** at 5 o'clock, on Monday, in June, since 2020, for two hours, by evening.
- **Place:** at the bus stop, on the table, in the room, under the bridge, between the two houses.
- **Direction:** to the market, into the house, across the road, towards the school.
- Rule: *at* for a point (at the door, at 9 a.m.), *on* for a surface or day (on the wall, on Friday), *in* for an enclosed space or longer period (in the box, in 2025).

(g) Conjunction

A conjunction joins words, phrases or clauses.

Kind	Function	Examples
Coordinating	Joins equal parts	and, but, or, so, yet, for, nor
Subordinating	Joins a dependent clause to a main clause	because, although, if, unless, when, while, since, after, before
Correlative	Used in pairs	either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only...but also

(h) Interjection

An interjection is a word that expresses sudden emotion and is not grammatically connected to the sentence: *Hurrah! We won. Alas! He is gone. Oh! I forgot. Wow! What a view.* It is followed by an exclamation mark or a comma.

4. Auxiliary Verbs

Auxiliary verbs (helping verbs) are used with a main verb to form tenses, questions, negatives, the passive voice, and to show ability, possibility, permission or obligation. In *She **is** singing*, 'is' is the auxiliary and 'singing' is the main verb.

Primary auxiliaries: be, have, do

Verb	Forms	Use	Example
be	am, is, are, was, were, been, being	Continuous tenses and passive voice	He is reading. The door was opened.
have	have, has, had	Perfect tenses	They have arrived.
do	do, does, did	Questions, negatives, emphasis	Do you know her? I did not go.

These three verbs can also be main verbs: *She **has** a car. They **are** students. I **do** my homework.*

Modal auxiliaries

Modals always come with the base form of a verb, have no -s in the third person and have no infinitive or -ing form.

Modal	Meaning / use	Example
can	Ability, permission (informal), possibility	I can swim. Can I go out?
could	Past ability, polite request	He could run fast. Could you help me?
may	Permission (formal), possibility	May I come in? It may rain.
might	Weaker possibility	She might be late.
shall	Future with I/we, offer or suggestion	Shall we begin?
will	Future, promise, willingness	I will help you.
should	Advice, duty	You should see a doctor.
would	Polite request, habit in the past, conditional	Would you like tea? If I were rich, I would travel.
must	Strong obligation, strong certainty	You must wear a helmet. He must be tired.

Modal	Meaning / use	Example
ought to	Moral duty, advice	We ought to respect elders.

Forming questions and negatives: Put the auxiliary before the subject for a question (*Has she finished?*) and add *not* after it for a negative (*She has not finished*). If there is no auxiliary, use *do/does/did* (*Does he play? He does not play.*).

5. Singular and Plural

Number tells whether a noun refers to one (singular) or more than one (plural). Learning plural rules prevents common errors.

Rule	Examples
Most nouns add -s	book - books, pen - pens
Nouns ending in s, x, z, ch, sh add -es	bus - buses, box - boxes, church - churches, dish - dishes
Consonant + y: change y to i and add -es	city - cities, baby - babies
Vowel + y: add -s	boy - boys, key - keys
Nouns ending in f/fe: usually change to -ves	leaf - leaves, wife - wives, knife - knives (but roof - roofs, chief - chiefs)
Nouns ending in o: some add -es, some -s	potato - potatoes, hero - heroes; photo - photos, piano - pianos
Irregular plurals	man - men, woman - women, child - children, foot - feet, tooth - teeth, mouse - mice, ox - oxen, person - people
Same form in singular and plural	sheep, deer, fish, series, species
Foreign plurals	datum - data, crisis - crises, phenomenon - phenomena, syllabus - syllabi
Compound nouns: pluralise the main word	mother-in-law - mothers-in-law, passer-by - passers-by
Always plural	scissors, trousers, spectacles, clothes, police
Uncountable (no plural)	information, advice, furniture, luggage, news, knowledge, equipment

6. Active and Passive Voice

Voice shows whether the subject does the action or receives it. In the **active voice** the subject is the doer (*The cat caught the mouse*). In the **passive voice** the subject is acted upon (*The mouse was caught by the cat*).

How to change active to passive

- Make the object of the active sentence the subject of the passive sentence.
- Use the correct form of **be** (matching the tense) followed by the **past participle (V3)** of the main verb.
- Add **by** + the original subject (the agent), if it is important.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	She writes a letter.	A letter is written by her.
Present continuous	She is writing a letter.	A letter is being written by her.
Present perfect	She has written a letter.	A letter has been written by her.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple past	She wrote a letter.	A letter was written by her.
Past continuous	She was writing a letter.	A letter was being written by her.
Past perfect	She had written a letter.	A letter had been written by her.
Simple future	She will write a letter.	A letter will be written by her.
Modal	She can write a letter.	A letter can be written by her.

Other sentence types

- **Questions:** Did he break the glass? - Was the glass broken by him?
- **Commands:** Close the door. - Let the door be closed. / You are requested to close the door.
- **Two objects:** He gave me a book. - I was given a book. / A book was given to me.

When to use the passive

- When the doer is unknown or unimportant: *My bicycle was stolen.*
- When the action or the result is more important than the doer: *The bridge was built in 1990.*
- In formal, scientific and news writing: *The samples were heated to 100 degrees.*

Note: Intransitive verbs (arrive, sleep, die) have no object and therefore cannot be made passive.

7. Degrees of Comparison

Adjectives and adverbs have three degrees that show how much of a quality something has.

- **Positive degree:** no comparison. *Ravi is tall.*
- **Comparative degree:** compares two things. *Ravi is taller than Kumar.*
- **Superlative degree:** compares one thing with all others in a group (three or more). *Ravi is the tallest boy in the class.*

Rules of formation

Rule	Positive	Comparative	Superlative
One-syllable words: add -er, -est	small	smaller	smallest
Words ending in e: add -r, -st	wise	wiser	wisest
Consonant + y: change y to i	happy	happier	happiest
Short words with one vowel + one consonant: double the consonant	big	bigger	biggest
Words of two or more syllables: use more, most	beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful
Irregular	good / well	better	best
Irregular	bad / ill	worse	worst
Irregular	much / many	more	most
Irregular	far	farther / further	farthest / furthest
Irregular	old	older / elder	oldest / eldest

Changing degrees without changing meaning

- **Superlative to comparative:** Ravi is the tallest boy. = Ravi is taller than any other boy.

- **Superlative to positive:** Ravi is the tallest boy. = No other boy is as tall as Ravi.
- **Comparative to positive:** She is wiser than he. = He is not as wise as she.

Always use **than** after a comparative and **the** before a superlative. Do not use double comparatives or superlatives (not 'more better', 'most easiest').

8. Determiners

A determiner is a word placed before a noun to make clear which person or thing is meant, or how many or how much. A noun phrase usually needs a determiner: we say *the book*, *my book* or *some books*, not just *book* (for a singular countable noun).

Kind	Words	Examples
Articles	a, an, the	a pen, an apple, the sun
Demonstratives	this, that, these, those	this book, those boys
Possessives	my, your, his, her, its, our, their	our school
Quantifiers	some, any, much, many, few, a few, little, a little, enough, all, most	many students, little water
Numerals	one, two, first, second	two cups, the third day
Distributives	each, every, either, neither, both	each child, every day
Interrogative	which, what, whose	Which bus? Whose pen?

Using articles correctly

- **a** goes before a consonant *sound*: a book, a university (starts with a 'yoo' sound), a one-rupee coin.
- **an** goes before a vowel *sound*: an apple, an hour (silent h), an MBA.
- **the** is used for something specific or already mentioned, unique things (the sun, the moon), rivers, seas, mountain ranges, and superlatives (the best).
- **No article** is used with plural or uncountable nouns in a general sense (Books are useful; Honesty is the best policy), names of people, most countries and meals.
- **few / little** have a negative sense (hardly any); **a few / a little** have a positive sense (some). 'He has few friends' = he is lonely. 'He has a few friends' = he has some.

Much / many / few / little: use *many* and *few* with countable nouns; use *much* and *little* with uncountable nouns.

9. Subject-Verb Agreement

The verb must agree with its subject in **number** (singular or plural) and **person**. Singular subjects take singular verbs (the third-person singular present adds -s/-es) and plural subjects take plural verbs.

Rule	Example
1. A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb.	The boy plays. The boys play.
2. Two or more subjects joined by *and* take a plural verb.	Ravi and Kumar are friends.
3. But if the two joined subjects mean one thing, the verb is singular.	Bread and butter is my breakfast.
4. With *or, nor, either...or, neither...nor*, the verb agrees with the subject nearer to it.	Neither the teacher nor the students were present.

Rule	Example
5. Words between the subject and the verb do not change the verb.	The box of apples is heavy.
6. Each, every, either, neither, one, everyone, someone, nobody take a singular verb.	Everyone is here. Each of the girls has a book.
7. Collective nouns take a singular verb when the group acts as one, a plural verb when members act separately.	The team has won. The team are arguing among themselves.
8. Subjects joined by *with, along with, together with, as well as* do not change the verb.	The teacher, along with her students, is going.
9. Plural-looking subjects that are singular in meaning take singular verbs (news, mathematics, physics, measles).	The news is good. Mathematics is difficult.
10. Expressions of money, time and distance as a whole amount take a singular verb.	Ten kilometres is a long walk.
11. A number as a unit takes a singular verb; the number of takes singular, a number of takes plural.	The number of students is 40. A number of students are absent.
12. In *there is / there are*, the verb agrees with the noun that follows.	There are five books on the desk.

10. Punctuation

Punctuation marks are symbols that show the pauses, stops and tone of written language. They make meaning clear: *Let's eat, Grandma!* and *Let's eat Grandma!* mean very different things.

Mark	Uses	Examples
Full stop (.)	Ends a statement or command; used in abbreviations.	I live in Puducherry. / Dr. Rao
Comma (,)	Separates items in a list; separates an introductory word or clause; sets off extra information; used before conjunctions joining two clauses; after yes/no and in direct address.	I bought rice, dal, and oil. / However, he agreed. / Ravi, come here.
Question mark (?)	Ends a direct question (not an indirect question).	What is your name? / He asked what my name was.
Exclamation mark (!)	Shows strong feeling, surprise or a command.	What a surprise!
Colon (:)	Introduces a list, explanation or quotation; separates hours and minutes.	You need three things: a pen, a book, and a bag.
Semicolon (;)	Joins two closely related independent clauses; separates complex list items.	She was tired; she went to sleep.
Apostrophe (')	Shows possession and contractions.	Ravi's book; the girls' room; don't; it's (it is). Its = possessive: The dog wagged its tail.
Quotation marks (" ")	Enclose the exact words spoken, titles of short works.	He said, "I will come."
Hyphen (-)	Joins parts of compound words; splits words at line end.	well-known, mother-in-law, twenty-one

Mark	Uses	Examples
Dash (-)	Shows a sudden break or adds emphasis.	He had one fear - failure.
Brackets ( )	Enclose extra information.	Mumbai (formerly Bombay) is large.
Capital letters	First word of a sentence, proper nouns, I, days, months, titles.	Monday, Chennai, Dr. Kalam

11. Common Errors and Usage

Learners often repeat certain mistakes. Knowing them helps you check your own speech and writing.

Category	Wrong	Correct
Agreement	He don't know the answer.	He doesn't know the answer.
Agreement	Each of the boys have a pen.	Each of the boys has a pen.
Tense	I have seen him yesterday.	I saw him yesterday.
Tense	I am knowing him.	I know him.
Tense	She is living here since 2020.	She has been living here since 2020.
Comparison	She is more taller than me.	She is taller than me.
Comparison	This is the most best book.	This is the best book.
Articles	He is an European.	He is a European.
Articles	She is the best of the all.	She is the best of all.
Uncountable nouns	He gave me many advices.	He gave me much advice.
Uncountable nouns	The furnitures are new.	The furniture is new.
Countable / uncountable	Less students came.	Fewer students came.
Prepositions	I am good in English.	I am good at English.
Prepositions	He is married with a doctor.	He is married to a doctor.
Prepositions	She is angry on me.	She is angry with me.
Gerund after 'to'	I look forward to meet you.	I look forward to meeting you.
Pronouns	Me and him went there.	He and I went there.
Pronouns	Between you and I.	Between you and me.
Word order	He asked me where was I going.	He asked me where I was going.
Double negative	I don't know nothing.	I don't know anything.
Confused words	I will lose my way. (lose / loose)	I do not want to lose it. The knot is loose.
Confused words	Their going home. (their / they're)	They're going home.

Strategy: Check each sentence for (1) subject-verb agreement, (2) correct tense, (3) correct preposition, (4) correct article, and (5) correct word form. Read the corrected sentence aloud so the right form becomes natural.